

F

Faces

The flat surfaces that make a crystal's external shape.

Facet, faceting

The cutting and polishing of multiple flat surfaces (facets) on a gem. The cut is named according to the number and shape of the facets.

Fancy

A gem cut with an unconventional shape, such as a heart.

Fire

See *Dispersion*.

Fluorescence, fluorescent

The glow of some gems under ultraviolet light, caused by impurities in their crystal structure.

Fracture

A mineral breakage or chipping unconnected to cleavage planes, which is thus often uneven.

Freeform cut

A fancy cut that does not follow a regular geometric pattern.

G

Geode

A rock cavity, often rounded, that is lined with crystals.

Girdle

A band around the widest part of a cut gem, dividing the crown and the pavilion.

Granular

Having grains, or being in the form of grains.

Groundmass

A fine-grained rock in which larger crystals are set or upon which they rest. See also *Matrix*.

H

Habit

The external shape in which a crystal grows because of its molecular structure.

I

Idiochromatic

A self-coloured gem, in which the colour comes from its chemical composition, not from impurities.

Igneous

A type of rock formed from solidified molten rock.

Inclusion

A crystal or fragment of another substance occurring within a gem; it is sometimes a way of identifying a species of gem.

Intaglio

A design in which the subject is cut lower than the background; the reverse of a cameo. See also *Cameo*.

Intrusive

An igneous rock that has solidified within other rocks under the Earth's surface.

Iridescence, iridescent

The rainbow array of colours displayed when light reflects off elements within a gem.

K

Karat

A unit describing the purity of gold. It refers to the amount of gold in 24 parts of a gold alloy. 24-karat is pure gold; 18-karat is three-quarters gold; 12-karat is half gold; and so on. See also *Carat*.

L

Lapidary

A person who cuts and polishes gems.

Lustre

The shine of a gem, which is caused by reflected light.

M

Massive

A mineral that has no definite shape or consists of small crystals in masses.

Matrix

The rock in which a gem is found. Also known as groundmass, host rock, or parent rock.

Metamorphic

A rock that has been transformed from one type of rock into another, due to the effects of heat or pressure, or a combination of the two.

Microcrystalline

A mineral habit in which crystals are too small to be seen with the naked eye.

Mineral

An inorganic, naturally occurring material that has a fixed chemical composition and a regular internal atomic structure.

Mixed cut

A cut in which the facets above and below the girdle differ. This usually takes the form of a brilliant cut above and a step cut below.

Mohs scale

The measure of a gem's relative hardness based on its resistance to scratching.

Mounting

The jewellery piece that a gem is, or gems are, set into. Also called a setting.

N

Native element

A chemical element that occurs naturally uncombined with other elements.

O

Opalescence

A bluish-white form of iridescence.

Ore

A rock or mineral from which a metal can be commercially extracted.

Organic gem

A gem that is composed of material made by, or from, living organisms.